Similarly, it was not difficult for these persons and agencies to manage the activities of a person like Bhindranwale, who was originally the creation of the 1 Akbar Road group itself, but who over a period of time started drifting – or more appropriately, was intentionally allowed to drift – from his original mentors, to help him shake off the impression that he was actually the creation of the 1 Akbar Road group. Naturally, the group had no objection to that, provided Bhindranwale's activities did not cross their 'comfort zone', which could force them to act prematurely or run the risk of Indira Gandhi further losing credibility.

A police officer is murdered

As mentioned in Chapter 4, Avtar Singh Atwal, DIG of police, Jalandhar Range, and former senior superintendent of police of Amritsar district, was shot dead on 25 April 1983 on the steps of the Golden Temple. The emasculated state machinery let his body lie where he fell, in full public view, for over two hours before it was 'allowed' to be retrieved. The message that it conveyed was, if the government could not act against Atwal's killers hiding in the Golden Temple complex or in Guru Nanak Niwas, how could it save the lives of ordinary citizens from the same killers, now emboldened by the government's inaction? This instilled yet even more fear in the minds of the general population. Little did anyone realize that taking action against the killers at that stage did not fit in with the 1 Akbar Road group's plan.

While posted as SSP, Amritsar, Atwal had been able to plant one of his sources in close proximity to Bhindranwale in order to secure information on his and his men's activities. It was through this source that Atwal came to know that on 15 March 1983, two members of Bhindranwale's killer squad were planning to carry out an assigned task. Based on that information, Atwal deployed SP Hqr, Amritsar, G.D. Pandey, to lay a trap at Manawala bridge on the Grand Trunk Road going towards Jalandhar.

As expected, at around 4.30 a.m., a jeep stopped in front the temporary naka (barrier) installed by Pandey's men. Finding their way blocked, the occupants of the jeep threw a hand grenade